PRD: Smart Therapist Matching Engine

Project: Smart Therapist Matching Engine

Product: YourDOST Web & Mobile App

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Status: Draft / In Review

Target Release: Q3 2026 (MVP)

1. Problem Alignment

The Problem

Selecting a therapist on YourDOST is currently driven by a static directory where users manually filter through dozens of profiles filled with clinical jargon (*e.g., CBT, REBT, Eclectic Modality*). For users seeking help—especially college students and corporate employees experiencing acute stress or burnout—this process causes high cognitive friction, decision paralysis, and frequent churn after session 1 due to mismatched expectations or lack of cultural fit.

High-Level Approach

We are replacing the manual directory search with a **Guided Algorithmic Matching Engine**. Through a brief, empathetic 2-minute onboarding questionnaire, we collect structured inputs regarding the user's primary concerns, preferred therapy style, and cultural/language preferences. A hybrid scoring algorithm processes these inputs against our therapist database to recommend the **Top 3 Best-Matched Therapists** with explicit match explanations.

Goals & Success

- **Primary Goal:** Eliminate choice overload and increase the likelihood of a successful therapeutic alliance on the first attempt.
- **Success Metrics:**
    - **First-to-Second Session Retention:** Increase conversion from **<55% to >80%**.
    - **Match Acceptance Rate: >70%** of users book one of the top 3 recommended therapists without falling back to the full directory.
    - **Clinical Progress Index (CPI):** Significant reduction in user self-reported distress scores (PHQ/GAD adaptations) after 4 sessions.

Key Assumptions

1. Users prioritize speed, relevance, and clinical/cultural fit over having access to an exhaustive list of all available therapists.
2. Users are willing to spend 90–120 seconds completing a structured intake questionnaire if it guarantees a curated, high-confidence match.
3. A transparent "Match Reason" builds trust faster than presenting uncontextualized profile cards.

2. Solution Alignment

Core User Stories

ID	As a...	I want to...	So that...
US-01	First-time user	Answer a short, conversational intake questionnaire	I can express my core concerns without needing to understand clinical psychology terms.
US-02	Stressed corporate/college user	See my Top 3 recommended therapists with specific match reasons	I can make a confident, quick decision without feeling overwhelmed by choice.
US-03	User with specific cultural/language needs	Specify my preferred language, age group, and communication style	I feel comfortable opening up to someone who understands my background and context.
US-04	User who completed Session 1	Provide 1-click feedback on how comfortable I felt	The system can confirm match quality or seamlessly offer a re-match if it didn't fit.

Key Features & MVP Scope

1. Empathetic Onboarding Intake (P0)

- A 5 to 7 question guided flow capturing:
    - **Primary Stressor / Concern:** (e.g., Workplace Burnout, Career Confusion, Academic Anxiety, Relationship Issues).
    - **Therapy Style Preference:** (e.g., Action-oriented/Directive vs. Exploratory/Listener).
    - **Cultural & Communication Preferences:** (e.g., Hinglish, English, Hindi; Corporate vs. Student background context).

2. Recommendation Engine & Match Cards (P0)

- Displays a curated view of **Top 3 Recommended Therapists**.
- Includes **"Why this match?"** badge on each card (*e.g., "95% Match: Specializes in corporate burnout + solution-focused approach + fluent in Hinglish"*).
- Direct 1-click calendar slot selection and booking integration.

3. Post-Session Match Pulse Check (P1)

- Automated post-session 1 check-in: *"How did your first session go?"*
- If response is negative, provides a **Frictionless Re-Match Guarantee** (re-runs matching engine with adjusted parameters at zero penalty).

3. Scope & Out of Scope

In Scope (MVP)

- Guided intake questionnaire for web and mobile platforms.
- Rule-based + weighted scoring matching algorithm.
- Top 3 recommendations screen with match justifications.
- Post-session 1 feedback mechanism.

Out of Scope (Saved for Phase 2)

- **ML / Collaborative Filtering:** Machine learning models that dynamically recalculate weights based on multi-month therapy outcome history (deferred until initial intake data volume is established).
- **Real-time Live Chat Matching:** Instantly connecting users to currently active/online therapists.
- **Automated Clinical Diagnosis Tools:** Intake questionnaire is strictly for matching preferences, not diagnostic or clinical assessment.